

FREEDOM STRUGGLE

# Free SPIRIT

Independent India was the culmination of a thousand rebellions, individual and collective. For many, the stories are still untold but the end, of liberation, is one they are proud of.

■ By Priya Sahgal

It was Mao Tse Tung who said that a revolution is not a dinner party. He added that there is nothing respectful, polite or modest about it. Yet it was not just the men but also women—modest housewives, polite and respectful 13-year-old girls—who took to the streets and fought against the British rule in India. There is the curious case of a young married woman imprisoned in Lahore in the 1930s for taking part in an organised protest. When her husband learnt of it, he forbade her from returning home, saying that while he was proud that his wife

had taken part in the nationalist movement, he was upset that she hadn't taken his permission first. As more and more women responded to Mahatma Gandhi's call, it was also the beginning of the feminist movement in India. The struggle for independence transcended all barriers and prejudice.

Twelve-year-old Vijay Chauhan was imprisoned for shouting "*Angrezon, Bharat chhodo* (Englishmen, leave India)", in Lahore's Anarkali Bazaar. Seventy-seven today, she needs a walking stick, but her spirit remains unconquered. She recalls how,

**THE GREAT BOYCOTT: An Indian lies in front of a cartload of imported clothes in Bombay in 1930**

